OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Cultural immersion training funding: Steve Prothero questions Shoalhaven Council

Sent 5 July 2026 · To Council Email · Response requested by 26 July 2026

5 July 2026
Andrew Constance
Chief Executive Officer
Shoalhaven City Council

cc: Mayor Patricia White; all Councillors

Dear Mr Constance,

I write in the knowledge that correspondence from this publication has, in recent months, been declined on the basis of guidance relating to unreasonable conduct. I note, for the record, that the application of that guidance to a public interest publication with more than 3,800 local readers is itself a matter currently before the NSW Ombudsman. The questions in this letter are not personal complaints. They are questions of public administration, put openly, on behalf of a readership that represents approximately 5.2 per cent of Shoalhaven's registered voters. They are questions any member of the public could put at an ordinary council meeting. I put them here, in writing, on the public record — and will publish whatever response is received, including none.

I am writing about a specific claim that has been put to me by a source from Council, and which I have not independently verified.

I want to give Council the opportunity to confirm, deny, or explain the position.

My source's account is this:

- that approximately $40,000 in funding allocated for cultural immersion training for Council staff has been redirected out of that program and folded into Council's general fund.
- My source further states that cultural immersion training has been delivered to the Executive Management Team, Directors and Section Managers, but has not been extended to the rest of the workforce, despite what they describe as years of repeated requests from Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander staff.

I am not in a position to confirm the figure, the transfer, or how the training rollout has actually progressed. I put the following questions to the Mayor, Councillors and yourself, as the officer responsible for the budget and the workforce:

1. **Has any funding allocated for cultural immersion training for Council staff been redirected into general revenue? If so, how much, when, and on whose authority?**
2. **What is the current status of the cultural immersion training program? It is reported to have reached Executive Management, Directors and Section Managers — has it been delivered to any staff beyond those levels, and if not, why not?**
3. **How many requests have Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander staff made for this training to be extended, over what period, and what response have they received?**
4. **Will Council commit publicly to fully funding and delivering this training, with a timeline, before next year's NAIDOC Week?**

Council's own 2009 Statement of Commitment — still printed at the front of every Aboriginal Advisory Committee agenda — promises to "ensure all Council staff and Councillors are exposed to ongoing education and cultural training and development programs."

Seventeen years on, these questions go to whether that commitment still means anything.

Yours faithfully,

Steve Prothero
Eye on Shoalhaven

Note to councillors receiving a copy of this letter: The questions above are put to the Mayor and CEO on the public record. If you believe they warrant answers, you are in a position to raise them directly in the chamber — through a Question on Notice, a Notice of Motion, or a question to the Mayor in open council. That is one of the most effective ways to place these matters on the public record in a forum where a response cannot be declined. This publication will report whatever is raised and whatever is answered.
